



RITU RAJ KONWAR

Kuldeep Kumar sets new national pole vault record



In his first indoor competition, Kuldeep Kumar set a new national record in pole vault by clearing 5.41m at the 1st Indian Indoor Open Combined Events and Pole Vault Competition at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar.

Kuldeep, the 21-year-old vaulter from Madhya Pradesh, surpassed the previous national record of 5.40m, set last year by State-mate Dev Meena. He also improved the national indoor record of 5.30m set by Reegan G., who took the silver with 5.25m, in March.

Kuldeep had three failed attempts at 5.46m, while the qualifying mark for the Asian Games is set at 5.45m.

He has been in impressive form. Earlier in April, he secured gold in Jaipur by clearing 5.25m, achieving the qualification mark for the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Meena, who had equalled his national record of 5.40m in March in Taiwan, settled for the bronze with 5.20m.

TEAM SPORTSTAR

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



The much-vaunted Shooting League of India may have been repeatedly delayed but National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) president Kalikesh Singh Deo is insistent that it would be held sooner than later.

"There is a challenge for every sport today on how to make it more commercially marketable, more television and viewer friendly and attract more fans. There may be a delay in the franchise-based league, first of its kind in the world, but we will not tolerate failure. We will make sure the SLI happens and is a success," Deo said on the sidelines of an event to mark the 75th anniversary of the National Rifle Association of India.

The NRAI also unveiled a special commemorative logo and launched a mobile application for athlete management including shooters registration and issuing certificates among others. Deo also announced a nationwide grassroots initiative to bring more youngsters into shooting. "Our vision is to make the sport more accessible, aspirational and engaging for the next generation. We plan to expose 7.5 lakh youth to shooting before the next Olympics through a hands-on 10-shot experience," he added.

UTHRA GANESAN